Marta Morando

m.morando1@lse.ac.uk ◇ martamorando.com ◇ +39 340 8612 036

LSE, Houghton Street, London WC2A 2AE ◇ Updated: October 2026. Click here for the most updated version.

Doctoral studies

London School of Economics and Political Science 2023–present
PhD in Economics.

References

Tim Besley
London School of Economics
t.besley@lse.ac.uk

Noam Yuchtman
London School of Economics
n.yuchtman@lse.ac.uk

Oriana Bandiera
London School of Economics
o.bandiera@lse.ac.uk

Robin Burgess
London School of Economics
r.burgess@lse.ac.uk

Prior education

London School of Economics and Political Science 2021–2023
MRes in Economics. *Distinction.*

Bocconi University 2018–2021
MSc in Economic and Social Sciences. *Summa cum laude.*

Bocconi University 2015–2018
BSc in Economic and Social Sciences. *Summa cum laude.*

Research fields

Public, Political, Labour Economics (primary)
Organisational, Environmental Economics (secondary)

Affiliations

Suntory and Toyota International Centres for Economics and Related Disciplines (STICERD, LSE) 2023–
Economics of Environment and Energy Programme, STICERD, LSE 2026–

Job market paper

Make or Buy the State? Consulting in the Public Sector

Abstract: What objectives guide the organisation of public production? I examine the role of productivity gains and citizens' policy preferences in the context of consulting services in Italy. Using a natural experiment that relaxed limits on municipal consulting expenditure, I show that access to consulting improves productivity: it boosts public service output while lowering budgetary needs. These effects are accompanied by a reorganisation of internal capacity: municipalities spend less on in-house employees, reducing the number of low-skilled administrative workers. Despite these productivity gains, a large-scale survey with embedded AI-led interviews reveals that citizens are willing to pay higher taxes to protect public employment and cut consulting. Interviews and information experiments show that this is partly motivated by beliefs that consulting is economically wasteful. Information on the economic benefits of consulting reduces citizens' willingness to pay for public employment by 40%, but does not eliminate it. The residual willingness to pay is consistent with perceived local economic benefits from public sector employment. Citizens' policy preferences can help explain why states choose less productive arrangements. In a second survey, politicians and senior bureaucrats reduce their support for consulting when informed of citizens' demand for public employment. Taken together, these results suggest that states face a trade-off between improving productivity and responding to citizens' beliefs and preferences over how public production is organised.

Working papers

Polarized Technologies

with Gaia Dossi · CEP Discussion Paper No. 2116, 2026

Abstract: We study whether, and how, societal views about which problems are most important or worth solving are reflected in the direction of technological progress. Compared to Republican inventors, Democrats are more likely to patent technologies addressing climate-change mitigation or women's reproductive health and less likely to patent weapons. These gaps are not explained by differences in inventive ability, persist within organizations, have strengthened over the past two decades, and also appear in subsequent innovation. Together, societal views and their polarization appear to be important drivers of technological change, operating in part through inventors' technology choices, with implications for innovation policy.

The Geography of Development Programs

with Beyza Gulmezoglu and Eddy Zou

Abstract: International organisations devote substantial resources to reaching the poorest segments of the population. Yet we know little about how these resources are distributed and why. In this paper, we provide the first systematic evidence on where development programs go within countries. We assemble a new dataset linking roughly 5,000 geocoded World Bank projects across 130 countries since 1995 to district-level nighttime lights and complete records of the personnel assigned to each project. We find that aid flows disproportionately to richer areas: 51% of World Bank projects exhibit positive "site selection," landing in districts significantly richer than their neighbours in the same province. In contrast, only about one-third of World Bank projects are targeted to poorer districts. The pattern is pervasive across sectors and is not explained by population-based targeting. It does not reflect a gain in performance: projects in richer areas are no more successful according to the World Bank's own independent ratings. Supply-side factors related to World Bank personnel help explain where projects are located. World Bank project managers, who have substantial discretion over choosing project locations, account for a sizeable share of the total variation in site selection, more than year, sector, and country fixed effects combined. We unpack the role of career incentives, managerial skills, and learning in driving site selection. These findings suggest that where aid goes within countries is shaped not only by the needs of the recipient country but also by the organizational structure of the agencies that deliver it.

The Cost of Identity: Theory and Experimental Evidence from the Energy Labour Market

with Gaia Dossi and Matthew OBrien

Abstract: Coming soon.

Work in progress

A Guide on How to Interview with AI

Short abstract: AI-led interviews are a key tool for understanding people's views and reasoning at scale. This paper provides guidance on when and how to use them in online surveys, highlighting their potential benefits and costs.

Contributive Justice in the Workplace

with Jakob Akesson and Tim Besley

Short abstract: Do employees value their employer's contribution to society? We link Indian firm-level financial data to employee job reviews and study the introduction of mandatory corporate social responsibility spending. Using an event-study design, we find that firms subject to the mandate increase their social spending and that their employees report higher job satisfaction. These findings suggest that workers derive value from their employers' contributions to society.

Organizations vs Occupations: Drivers of Job Satisfaction
with Jakob Akesson and Tim Besley

Short abstract: We combine existing surveys with large-scale employee-review data worldwide to examine which aspects of work are most closely associated with job satisfaction. We use review text to measure features of the work environment and relate them to overall satisfaction, alongside occupation and pay. Most of the variation in job satisfaction occurs within occupations. Across both data sources, management emerges as the strongest correlate of job satisfaction, ahead of pay.

Seminars & conferences

excluding presented by coauthors

** scheduled*

LSE POID Research Seminar (London, UK); BSE Summer Forum (Barcelona, Spain); LSE Department of Economics	2026
IEB Workshop on Political Economy (Barcelona, Spain); UniCredit Marco Fanno Alumni Workshop (Turin, Italy); Environmental Populism Conference (London, UK); NICEP Conference (Nottingham, UK); LSE PSPE Seminar (London, UK); LSE Department of Economics	2025
Hayek Workshop on Institutions and Political Economy in Historical Perspective (London, UK); Society for Economic Dynamics Annual Meeting (Barcelona, Spain); EEA-ESEM Annual Congress (Rotterdam, Netherlands); ASREC Europe Conference (Thessaloniki, Greece); Bristol Economics of Innovation Workshop (Bristol, UK, *invited*); Lewis Lab Graduate Student Workshop (Manchester, UK); LSE Department of Economics	2024
LSE POID Research Seminar (London, UK); LSE PSPE Seminar (London, UK); ACES Summer School in Political Economy (Berkeley, USA); LSE Department of Economics; Bocconi Christmas Workshop (Milan, Italy); Bocconi Summer Workshop (Milan, Italy)	2022–2023

Research grants

Total grant funding: approximately $51,000 (EUR 44,000)

STICERD PhD Grant, joint with Beyza Gulmezoglu and Eddy Zou (£5,000)	2026
Global School of Sustainability PhD Small Project Grant (£5,000)	2026
Programme on Cohesive Capitalism PhD Grant (£5,000)	2026
STICERD PhD Grant (£5,190)	2026
Google Cloud Research Credits Program ($980)	2026
STICERD PhD Grant (£5,000)	2024
STICERD PhD Grant, joint with Gaia Dossi (£5,000)	2023
STICERD Michio Morishima Fund (£700)	2023
LSE Phelan Research Grant (£2,500)	2023
STICERD Hayek Programme PhD Grant, joint with Gaia Dossi (£4,000)	2022

Awards

Cohesive Capitalism PhD scholarship	2024
LSE Teaching Bonus	2023–2025
LSE Class Teacher Award, based on student ratings	2023
Outstanding Distinction for the Bonaldo Stringher scholarship, Bank of Italy	2022
LSE Economics Departmental Award	2021
UniCredit Foundation *Fabrizio Saccomanni Scholarship*	2021
Fondazione Famiglia Legnanese scholarship	2019

Research experience

Research assistant to Tim Besley (London School of Economics)	2025–2026
Research assistant to Michael Callen (International Growth Centre & London School of Economics)	2023
Research assistant to Gilat Levy and Ronny Razin (London School of Economics)	2022
Research assistant to Paolo Pinotti (Bocconi University)	2020–2021
IGIER visiting student, mentored by Guido Tabellini (Bocconi University)	2019–2021
Research assistant to Swapnil Singh (Central Bank of Lithuania)	2019

Teaching

London School of Economics and Political Science

Graduate Teaching Assistant for:

– Introduction to Statistics (PP430E), Executive Master of Public Administration and Policy	2024
– Introduction to Quantitative Methods (PP408), Master of Public Administration	2024
– Pre-Sessional Coding and Mathematics Bootcamp (PP407), Master in Data Science for Policy	2024
– Econometrics 1 (EC1C1), undergraduate	2023–2025
– Microeconomics 1 (EC1A3), undergraduate	2022

Graduate Teaching Fellow for:

– Quantitative Methods for Public Policy (PP402), Master of Public Policy	2023

Academic service

Referee: Economica; Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization; Journal of Law, Economics and Organization

Discussant: BSE Summer Forum (2026); Arthur Lewis Lab Student Workshop (University of Manchester, 2024)

Organizer: Environmental Populism Conference (2025); LSE Applied Microeconomics Student-Only Seminar (2023–2024)

Co-Founder: LSE Applied Microeconomics Student-Only Seminar (2023)

Mentoring: LSE Academic Mentor for undergraduate students 2023–2024

Other: Managing LSE Economics database for Research Excellence Framework 2025–2026

Other writing

Polarisation is Not a Myth: Political Views Shape the Creation and Spread of Technology
with Gaia Dossi · *CentrePiece*, Centre for Economic Performance, LSE, Vol. 31, Issue 2, Summer 2026

Polarization is Not a Myth: It Is Reflected in the Creation and Diffusion of New Technologies
with Gaia Dossi · *LSE United States Politics and Policy Blog*, March 2026

Languages

Italian (native) · English (fluent) · Spanish (basic)

Citizenship

Italian